Mixed Numbers & Height Equivalence: 3/4 + 2 1/2

Fraction Addition & Mixed Numbers • Standard: CCSS.MATH.5.NF.A.1

BOOK STORY OPENER: The Pharaoh's Bakery, Pythagoras's Guitar Strings & Why Your Fraction Towers Stand 84.0 mm Tall

Four thousand years ago, Egyptian scribes had to divide 3 loaves of bread fairly among 4 workers—and instead of cutting every loaf into quarters, they gave each worker 1/2 + 1/4! In Chapter 5 of From Blocks to the Stack, students discover why the Whole block is engineered to 84.0 mm (LCM of 1,2,3,4,6,8,12 -> 84 mm), letting 42 mm (1/2) + 21 mm (1/4) stack flush with three 21 mm (3/4) blocks.

Companion Book: From Blocks to the Stack (SC-6 Manual) — Ch. 5: Fractions, Decimals & Ratios (The Pharaoh's Bakery & 84mm Comparator)

1. CONCRETE MANIPULATIVE SETUP

Manipulative Kit: 84 mm Fraction Towers & Twin Comparator Well

Place three 1/4 blocks (3 × 21 = 63 mm). Beside them, stack two Whole blocks and one 1/2 block (84 + 84 + 42 = 210 mm).

2. STUDENT PREDICTION (ASK BEFORE PRESSING KEYS)

Combine heights: 63 mm + 210 mm = 273 mm. In wholes: 3 1/4 (273 / 84 = 3.25).

3. CALCULATOR ACTION (SC-6 KEYCAPS & STACK TRACE)

Keystroke Flow: [•] [3] [•] [4] [ENTER] [2] [•] [1] [•] [2] [+]

Key Pressed	Screen (X)	Internal 4-Level Stack Effect (T, Z, Y, X)
[•]	0.	Leading dot indicates 0 wholes
[3]	0.3	Numerator = 3
[•]	0.3.	Second dot sets fraction entry mode
[4]	3/4	Denominator = 4: displays 3/4 (or 0.75)
[ENTER]	3/4	3/4 lifted to register Y
[2]	2	Whole = 2
[•]	2.	Dot
[1]	2.1	Numerator = 1
[•]	2.1.	Dot
[2]	2 1/2	Denominator = 2: displays 2 1/2
[+]	3 1/4	Plus combines: 3 1/4 (decimal 3.25)!

4. MATHEMATICAL EXPLANATION & RPN ADVANTAGE

Two dots eliminate ambiguity between decimals and fractions. Physical block heights provide an infallible self-check against the 84 mm comparator pillar.

Core Investigation Problem:

Build 1/2 and 1/4 with blocks. Verify their combined height against three 1/4 blocks, then check on the calculator.

Fraction Multiplication & Reciprocals

Fraction Multiplication & Inverses • Standard: CCSS.MATH.5.NF.B.4

1. FOLLOW-UP EXTENSION SETUP & PREDICTION

Setup: Set up 3/4 of a tower (63 mm) and divide into 3 equal parts (21 mm each), taking 2 parts: (3/4) × (2/3). Prediction: 3/4 × 2/3 = 6/12 = 1/2. The resulting block height matches one 1/2 block (42 mm).

2. EXTENSION KEYSTROKE SEQUENCE & STACK TRACE

[•] [3] [•] [4] [ENTER] [•] [2] [•] [3] [×]

Key Pressed	Screen (X)	Internal 4-Level Stack Effect
[•]	0.	Start proper fraction 3/4
[3]	0.3	Numerator 3
[•]	0.3.	Fraction separator
[4]	3/4	3/4 in register X
[ENTER]	3/4	3/4 lifted to register Y
[•]	0.	Start proper fraction 2/3
[2]	0.2	Numerator 2
[•]	0.2.	Fraction separator
[3]	2/3	2/3 in register X
[×]	1/2	Product 6/12 = 1/2 (matches 42 mm block)!

3. TARGET MISCONCEPTIONS & HANDS-ON BLOCK REMEDIATIONS

Misconception 1: Adding numerators and denominators directly (e.g., 1/2 + 1/4 = 2/6) because 6 looks larger.

Hands-On Block Remediation: Place the 1/2 tower (42 mm) + 1/4 tower (21 mm) beside two 1/6 towers (28 mm) in the comparator well; the physical height difference proves 1/2 + 1/4 = 3/4 (63 mm).

Misconception 2: Entering a proper fraction like 3/4 as [3] [.] [4] (which is decimal 3.4) instead of using Two-Dot fraction notation [.][3][.][4].

Hands-On Block Remediation: Teach the rule: 'First dot = whole number zero, second dot = fraction bar.' Typing [.][3][.][4] displays exact 3/4 on the stack.

4. EXTENSION MATHEMATICAL INSIGHT

Multiplying fractions scales the height. Dividing by 2/3 is identical to multiplying by its reciprocal 3/2.

Fraction Studio: Height Equivalence & Two-Dot Notation

Name: _____ Date: _____ Class: _____

STUDENT REFERENCE GUIDE: TWO-DOT FRACTION ENTRY & TOWER EQUIVALENCE

- One Whole tower stands 84.0 mm tall, dividing cleanly into halves (42 mm), thirds (28 mm), fourths (21 mm), sixths (14 mm), eighths (10.5 mm), and twelfths (7 mm).
- Twin Comparator Well: Stack equivalent fraction towers side-by-side against the 84.0 mm Whole tower to verify equivalence by sight and touch.
- Two-dot entry format: [WHOLE] [.] [NUMERATOR] [.] [DENOMINATOR] (or [a ᵇ/c] on SC-6).

Key Sequence: [•] [3] [•] [4] [ENTER] [2] [•] [1] [•] [2] [+]

Problem 1: Add 1/3 + 1/6 using fraction blocks and verify on the calculator.

1. Block Model / Sketch:

2. Mathematical Strategy & Work:

3. Prediction: _____

Final Answer: _____

[ ] Checked on SC-6

Problem 2: Calculate 1 1/2 - 3/4. What block height corresponds to this?

1. Block Model / Sketch:

2. Mathematical Strategy & Work:

3. Prediction: _____

Final Answer: _____

[ ] Checked on SC-6

Problem 3: Compare 3/8 (31.5 mm) to 1/2 (42 mm). What is the decimal equivalent of 3/8?

1. Block Model / Sketch:

2. Mathematical Strategy & Work:

3. Prediction: _____

Final Answer: _____

[ ] Checked on SC-6

Problem 4: Multiply 2/3 × 3/4. Check against your fraction blocks.

1. Block Model / Sketch:

2. Mathematical Strategy & Work:

3. Prediction: _____

Final Answer: _____

[ ] Checked on SC-6

Unit 06: Fraction Studio: Height Equivalence & Two-Dot Notation — Answer Key

Complete solutions and SC-6 verification keystrokes for Grades 4–5

1. CORE & EXTENSION INVESTIGATION SOLUTIONS

Core Investigation: Build 1/2 and 1/4 with blocks. Verify their combined height against three 1/4 blocks, then check on the calculator.

Core Solution: 3/4 (height 63 mm). Keystrokes: [.][1][.][2] [ENTER] [.][1][.][4] [+]

Core Check Keys: [•] [1] [•] [2] [ENTER] [•] [1] [•] [4] [+]

Extension Challenge: Calculate 2/3 × 3/8 using fraction blocks and verify on the calculator. What block height matches the product?

Extension Solution: 1/4 (height 21 mm). Keystrokes: [.][2][.][3] [ENTER] [.][3][.][8] [×]

Ext. Check Keys: [•] [2] [•] [3] [ENTER] [•] [3] [•] [8] [×]

2. STUDENT LAB WORKSHEET SOLUTIONS (PROBLEMS 1–4)

Problem 1: Add 1/3 + 1/6 using fraction blocks and verify on the calculator.

Expected Answer: 1/2 (42 mm)

SC-6 Verification Keys: [•] [1] [•] [3] [ENTER] [•] [1] [•] [6] [+]

Problem 2: Calculate 1 1/2 - 3/4. What block height corresponds to this?

Expected Answer: 3/4 (63 mm)

SC-6 Verification Keys: [1] [•] [1] [•] [2] [ENTER] [•] [3] [•] [4] [-]

Problem 3: Compare 3/8 (31.5 mm) to 1/2 (42 mm). What is the decimal equivalent of 3/8?

Expected Answer: 0.375

SC-6 Verification Keys: [•] [3] [•] [8] [FDISP]

Problem 4: Multiply 2/3 × 3/4. Check against your fraction blocks.

Expected Answer: 1/2 (42 mm)

SC-6 Verification Keys: [•] [2] [•] [3] [ENTER] [•] [3] [•] [4] [×]

Hands-On Block & Stack Verification Protocol

Students first build the physical block model and write their mathematical strategy and prediction before verifying their result on the StackCalc calculator.